# Proposed Plan of Study

Roman Jahandideh — PhD in Communication & Culture, Fall 2027

*Whose Contribution Counts? AI Mediation and Collective Authorship in Digital Improvisation*

In collaborative creative tools, a generative model reinterprets what participants contribute: one person's phrase becomes a sound or a moving form, and its output may become more visible than the contribution that prompted it. My doctoral research asks how participants, facilitators and a generative-AI interface shape whether a person's contribution is recognised, carries creative authority, and is credited in a collective work. This is a question of AI-mediated communication: I study AI not as a creative partner but as a medium that translates one person's offer to others, and ask whether the system's record of who supplied what matches how collaborators recognise one another. Table 1 shows where this extends the closest studies.

**Table 1.** Closest related work, as reported in each source.

| Study | AI's role | What this project adds |
|---|---|---|
| Xu et al. 2026 (CHI) | Shared ChatGPT in one group task | Improvisation; credit across sessions |
| Trajkova et al. 2024 (CHI) | Proposed AI dance partner, not yet tested | An implemented mediator in group work |
| Epstein et al. 2020 (*iScience*) | AI art described to online observers | Credit claimed by the people making the work |
| Caines 2026 (*AJSE*) | GenAI tools in course design | Recognition of individual contributions |

My objects of study are small-group digital improvisation workshops with adult improvisers, and the shared audiovisual environment I will build. A language model proposes transformations of participants' phrases into light, form and sound, which contributors or groups accept, revise or refuse. Using AI is always optional.

Under the research-creation option, the environment, improvised works and workshop-tested scores form the creative component. Methods are scoping interviews, co-design with practitioners, repeated workshops (provisionally three groups, four sessions each) comparing contributor-led, group-led and human-mediated arrangements, and video-based reflection interviews. The framework is Lucy Suchman's account of how agency is figured at the human–machine interface.

The project fits Technology in Practice, with Media & Culture as a minor. I hope to work with Dr. Rebecca Caines, whose research on improvisation as methodology, socially responsive creative technologies, and generative AI as a critical improvisation practice fits this approach.

I come to communication and culture through design. Trained in architecture (Tabriz Islamic Art University) and landscape architecture (Istanbul Technical University), I have always been curious about what my designs do to the people and communities who live with them. At Istanbul I studied perception of virtual environments (eCAADe 2023). In my thesis-based master's in Interactive Arts and Technology at Simon Fraser University, I built multiplayer systems that let remote teammates sense one another's heart-rate state without emotion labels, accepted at ACM ISS 2026. Participants accepted that display only if they controlled who saw it. That finding moved my question from what a design does to people to who controls how a shared system interprets them. I have run ethics-approved studies, worked as a teaching assistant, and served on SFU's Senate Graduate Studies Committee.